

Parity arguments for permissivism in ontology

PHIL UA-78 Metaphysics

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Parity arguments

Two examples from Fairchild and Hawthorne

1. There are objects, namely islands, that shrink as the surrounding ocean rises and are destroyed if completely submerged.
2. If there are such objects, then there are certain other objects, namely incars, objects that have the shape and location of a car while the car is in a garage, but, as the car leaves the garage, shrink to the size of whatever part of the car is in the garage.
3. Therefore, there are incars.

Two examples from Fairchild and Hawthorne

1. There are certain objects that are essentially roughly round and made of snow; namely, snowballs.
2. If there are such objects, then there are certain other objects made of snow that are roughly round, are not essentially roughly round, but are essentially somewhere in the shape-range from roughly round to disc-shaped.
3. Therefore, there are snowdiscs.

What motivates the conditional premises?

The thought is that there is no 'ontologically significant' difference between the two properties at issue. It would be 'bizarre' for the world to be set up in such a way that there are objects of this sort but not objects of that sort.

- ▶ Fairchild and Hawthorne give a helpful example: the view that there are tables but no chairs, only atoms arranged chairwise.
 - ▶ *Some* of the objections to this view are also objections to the view that there are neither tables nor chairs—e.g. that there just obviously are chairs.
 - ▶ But the objection we are interested in is not that, but to the implausibility of the *differential* treatment. The difference is 'not the right sort of thing to be a difference-maker'.

Arguments from strange communities

Ontological permissivists often invoke thought experiments involving communities where they treat it as obvious that there are things with some controversial spatial/temporal/modal profiles, similarly to how our community treats it as obvious that there are dogs, tables, etc.

One can use such thought experiments to give a *direct* argument for the controversial existence claims. The argument is as follows:

1. *Charity*: ordinary members of such communities would not be mistaken in taking there to be things with the relevant strange profiles.
2. If so, there are things with those strange profiles.

One can also use such thought experiments to motivate the conditional premise in a parity argument. Thought: it would be really weird if growing up in *that* community made for systematic mistakes, whereas growing up in our kind of community didn't.

Korman's responses to parity arguments

Korman on islands

According to Korman, islands do *not* shrink when water levels rise, or cease to exist when submerged, and indeed there are *no* objects that behave like this.

Nor, for that matter, do islands shrink when the water levels rise. Islands are like icebergs: part of the island is above water and the rest of the island is underwater. (Submarines sometimes crash into islands.) And, like icebergs, they shrink by eroding. To the extent that we are ever inclined to say that the island is shrinking when the water levels rise, it seems plausible on reflection that all that is shrinking is the part of the island that is above water, not the island itself. And even this is evidently a *façon de parler*. Nothing really becomes smaller when the part of the island that is above water gets smaller any more than something really becomes longer as the part of this sentence that you have read thus far gets longer.

(Korman is open to the idea that the island will cease to be an *island* when fully submerged, just as a person might cease to be a professor when fired.)

The part of the island that is above water

Korman's view: although 'The part of the island that is above water has shrunk' is true, 'Something has shrunk' is not true.

Analogy: arguably, 'The mayor has got younger/less powerful' can be true without 'Someone has got younger/less powerful' being true.

We know that definite descriptions give rise to logical surprises in sentences where they interact with things like modals, attitude verbs, and negation. It's not obvious that the standard explanations of this can be carried over to environments like '... has shrunk', but it's also not obvious that they can't.

Korman on artifacts and creative intentions

According to Korman, when a person acts to move matter around, certain features of the person's *intentions* are relevant to the question whether any new object came into existence and, if so, what the spatial, temporal, and modal profile of the new object were like.

For example: the very same acts of kneading clay into an unusual shape might, if accompanied by certain intentions, create a new object (a 'golyswoggle') that essentially has that shape, whereas if the kneading was done absent-mindedly, no new object would be created.

NB: not just anything goes! EG: Korman thinks that very slight rearrangements won't make anything new, even if we want them to (see F&H 33).

If you can live with the idea that such differences are ontologically significant, they provide a way of resisting the conditional premise in many parity arguments involving artifacts.

Oddities of the creative intentions view

You can imagine an artist filling a gallery with similar-looking clay artworks, some of which were made with the relevant intentions, others of which were made absent-mindedly but later selected because of their similar shape. The artist and everyone else might have forgotten which are which.

Suppose a janitor knocks one over, drastically altering its shape. Then on Korman's view, we just won't know whether the janitor destroyed anything, unless we can figure out whether this was one of the ones whose creation was accompanied by the intentions. Odd!

- Very relevant in real life to museums that contain artifacts from many cultures!